



MARY ANNING

English paleontologist
1799–1847

Fossils are rocks that show us the shape of ancient and extinct plants and animals.

In the 1800s, fossils were big business. Museums and collectors paid handsomely for the remains of long-dead plants and animals that had been frozen in time, and paleontologist Mary Anning had a knack for finding them. Mary was born in Lyme Regis, Dorset, UK, which is one of the best places in the world to find fossils. Her father collected fossils for fun and taught his children how to find them. When he died, selling these ancient wonders became the family's only source of money.

In 1811, Mary's brother spotted the most incredible fossil they'd ever seen—an enormous skull sticking out of a cliff.

Slowly and carefully, 12-year-old Mary dug the whole skeleton out of the rock. This skeleton would soon be known by the name *Ichthyosaurus*. Her career as a world-famous fossil hunter had begun.

The plesiosaur looked so strange that at first, other paleontologists thought it was fake!

Mary's plesiosaur is still on display at the Natural History Museum in London, UK.